

ACTIVITY 12 — FACILITATOR GUIDE**PR Campaign Budget Planning**

TYPE	DURATION	MAPS TO	TOPIC
Case Study	25 minutes	LU3	LU3 — Branding in Marketing

Purpose of this activity

By the end of this activity learners will be able to execute public-relations campaigns in alignment to brand positioning strategies, operational plans and budget (LU3).

What learners produce

A PR budget proposal: a percentage split across Paid/Earned/Shared/Owned, a reserve fund with a defined trigger, and Board-grade reputation KPIs.

Materials required

- Learner Worksheet (one per learner)
- Checklist (one per group)
- Flipchart or A3 sheet and markers
- The course slides for the scenario and framework
- Internet access where the activity calls for live research

Set-up

Groups of 3–5. Distribute one worksheet per learner and one checklist per group. All 17 activities run on the same continuous Nimbus Wellness scenario, so remind learners of where this activity sits in that story before you start.

Scenario / briefing material

The CEO has approved a bounded PR budget for the 5th-anniversary relaunch — but not a blank cheque. Before a single dollar is spent, the CEO wants to see it allocated across earned, owned and paid channels in a way that visibly matches Nimbus's brand positioning, not just whichever channel the Marketing team finds easiest to book.

The Board has already flagged a second concern for after the relaunch: they want ongoing proof the campaign improved Nimbus's reputation, not just its impression count — so today's budget plan needs KPIs the Board can actually hold the team to.

Your table has been asked to build the PR budget proposal the CEO will sign off on.

How to run it — step by step

#	Instruction to learners	Facilitator note
1	Anchor to positioning, not	Tables default to a paid-heavy split

	convenience. Write Nimbus's brand positioning and the perception gap at the top. Every allocation must be defensible against these, not against which channel is easiest for Marketing to book.	out of habit — ask whether buying reach can fix a trust problem.
2	Allocate across the four PESO channels. Assign a percentage to Paid, Earned, Shared and Owned. They must total 100% including your reserve. Write a one-line rationale beside each figure.	A reserve of roughly 10-15% with a named trigger is a realistic professional norm.
3	Justify the largest share. Name the channel taking the biggest share and argue why it is right for THIS relaunch. Given a credibility problem, Earned and Shared usually deserve more than Paid — paid reach does not repair trust, and a brand shouting louder about being personal tends to prove the opposite.	
4	Decide what to underfund deliberately. Name the channel you are consciously underfunding and why. Deliberate underfunding is a strategic decision; leaving something out silently is an oversight. The CEO will ask about this.	
5	Set the reserve and its trigger. Hold back a percentage and — critically — write what specific event would release it. A reserve without a trigger becomes either unspent or spent on impulse. The packaging-defect scenario in Activity 15 is exactly the kind of trigger to plan for.	
6	Define reputation KPIs, not reach KPIs. The Board wants proof of reputation improvement. Impressions and reach measure exposure. Sentiment shift, share of positive voice, review-score movement and earned-mention quality measure reputation. Choose the latter.	
7	Pressure-test the proposal. Have one person at the table play the CEO and challenge each allocation. Revise anything that cannot be defended in one sentence.	

Suggested timing

Minutes	Phase
4 min	Review positioning and the perception gap the budget must close
8 min	Allocate percentages across the PESO channels

5 min	Decide what to deliberately underfund and why
4 min	Set the reserve fund and its trigger
4 min	Define reputation KPIs the Board can hold the team to

Total: 25 minutes

Discussion & decision prompts

1. Using the PESO model, how should the budget split across paid, earned, shared and owned channels given Nimbus's brand positioning and the perception gap it's trying to close?
2. Which channel deserves the largest share of spend for this specific relaunch — and which would you deliberately underfund, and why?
3. What percentage, if any, should be held back as a reserve fund, and what would trigger Nimbus to actually spend it?
4. What KPIs would let the Board judge reputation improvement, not just reach or impressions?

Debrief

Bring the class back together and draw out the learning:

- Ask two or three groups to show what they produced, not just what they concluded.
- Ask what surprised them — the gap between what they assumed and what they found.
- Link the activity explicitly back to LU3 — Branding in Marketing.
- Remind learners this activity rehearses what the Case Study assessment will require.

Reflection questions:

- Did your allocation favour the channel that's easiest to execute, or the one the brand positioning actually calls for?
- How did you decide the size of the reserve fund — was it a rule of thumb or tied to a specific risk Nimbus is facing?
- If the Board rejected your KPI list as "just vanity metrics," what would you replace them with?

Facilitator notes — what to watch for

- Tables default to a paid-heavy split out of habit — ask whether buying reach can fix a trust problem.
- A reserve of roughly 10-15% with a named trigger is a realistic professional norm.

Success criterion

Every group can show a PR budget proposal with a percentage split across paid, earned, shared and owned channels, a stated reserve fund, and a KPI list the Board could use to judge reputation impact rather than reach alone.

Assessment link

This activity builds LU3 — Branding in Marketing. All 17 activities are in-class activities assessed indirectly through the open-book Case Study (CS) component, which reuses the same techniques on the same continuous Nimbus Wellness scenario. Knowledge is assessed in the Written Assessment (WA-SAQ). Nothing is assessed that is not practised here or taught in the slides.